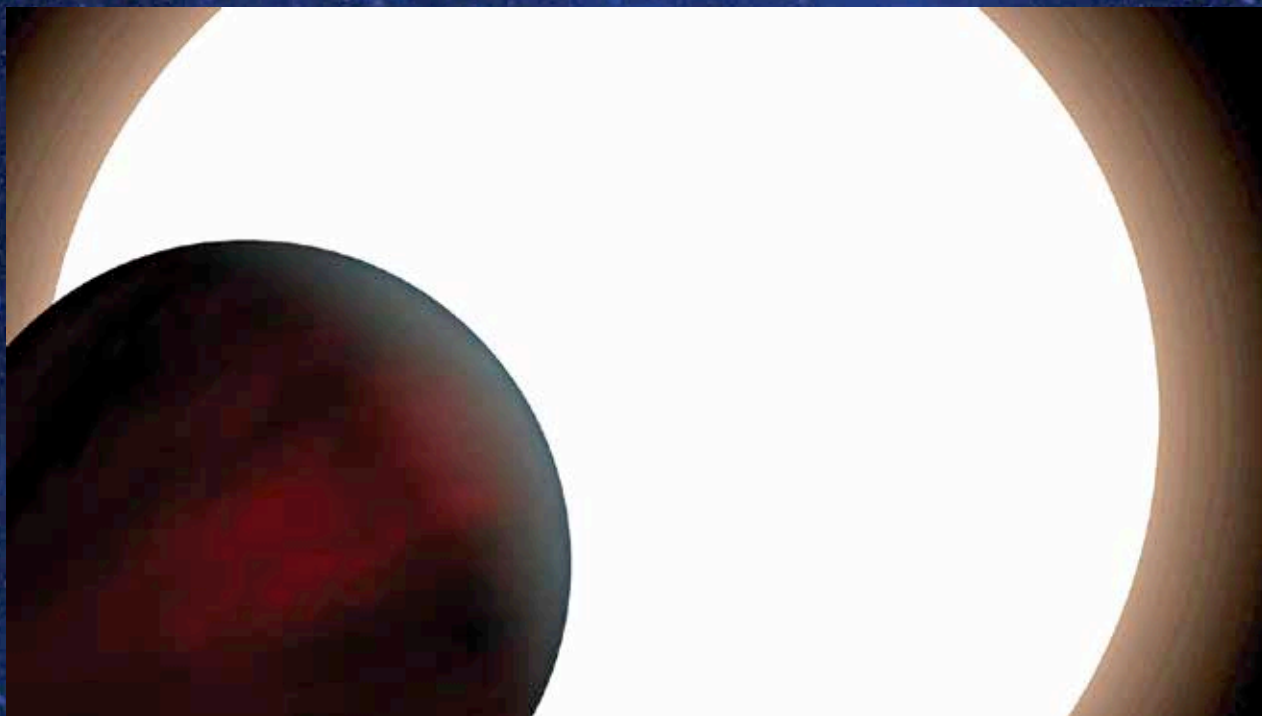




Are we alone?

How many of you have wondered, are we alone?

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No, you hopeless romantics, we do not mean this in terms of 'Is there someone for me?', we mean it more in terms of 'Is there life outside of Earth, somewhere in the galaxy?'

Well the root cause of this question being raised and astronomers toying with the possibility us not being alone was also raised by Kepler. This was because of one of the most popular discoveries that Kepler had which was termed the "Tabby's Star". To put it simply, there were strange images spotted of the behavior of light patterns. And, when these images got out, there were guesses made all around. Some thought that this is probably some alien inhabited planet that goes by the name of "Dyson

Sphere". The speculations were proven wrong when it was seen that the root of the strange images was dust but then Kepler was created to answer, the buring question, which was, 'Are we alone?'

But what is 'Kepler' in the first place?

For all of our readers not in the know, Kepler was a space telescope launched in 2009, on March 6 to be precise with the aim of finding exoplanets. The way of doing this would have been pretty simple as it would watch them cross in front of their stars. And it did spot a potential planet. But it was found out that this may be fake and it was dismissed as a false alarm. But three years ago, in 2019, astron-

omer Ashley Chontos and the people working with him proved that it was actually real and the planet was officially given the name of Kepler 1658b.

Was the process of discovering Kepler 1658 and Kepler 1658b really this smooth?

What some of you might not be aware of though, was that there was some dicey information that the astronomers thought was true, till they did further research on it. One of them was they thought that it is probably 1.1 times the width of the sun. For reference, that is about the size of the already-existing and known planet Neptune. But then a secondary eclipse happened. Ahh wait! Before you go on Googling what a secondary eclipse is, give us a chance. It is an occurrence of a second dip in the starlight that occurs when the an celestial body/system passes behind the star. So in an ideal situation, that should not happen with such a comparatively-small planet. Hence, they came to think of a situation where the scientists could not rule out the possibility of the exoplanet being existent